



R. V. MOORTHY

trained the kids. Then I received a call about this girls' academy. **The initial two-three months were awkward for me. Going to coach a women's team was considered a demotion.** *Beizzati vaali baat hai girls team mein daal rahein hain* (Coaching a girls' team used to be considered an embarrassment). But I also took it up as a challenge," Sen, a former Ranji Trophy player for Himachal, recalls.

The sight of 85 girls turning up for the first set of trials in Kangra

encouraged Sen. Sushma and Renuka were among those who attended the trials and also broke into the 25-member group selected as the academy's first batch.

But making a case to parents to send their daughters away for cricket was still a challenge. "In Himachal Pradesh, people want girls to get married by 23 or 24. Whenever I tried to convince them, they said, '*Kya milega khel ke?*' (What will they gain from playing cricket?)" and I had no answer," Sen says.

Eager to prove a point, Sen once enrolled his team in an open tournament in Kangra.

"There are 30-35 teams that take part every year. I enrolled our academy's team; all the girls were around 15 years old at that time. I was criticised from within HPCA as well. I just asked the girls not to look at who they were facing. Just play. We ended up reaching the final, and this created a huge buzz in the city. This was in 2010," Sen says.

The gamble worked. The result